The Accessibility Paradox: Challenges of Visibility, Autonomy, and Power in Digital Archiving

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Scholars, practitioners, and corporations of digital media often highlight the benefits of expanded access to production and dissemination tools, claiming it fosters a more democratic process of knowledge creation. While the advantages of increased access are well-documented, its contradictions—particularly in the context of digital archives of regional politics and culture—have received less attention. This presentation examines several key contradictions. First, market saturation can obscure non-institutional community-created archives, burying them like a needle in a haystack amidst the overwhelming volume of content—much like independent films that lack proper distribution and fail to reach audiences (see Putnam 2024). Additionally, the accessibility of digital tools often disguises the significant (and usually unpaid/underpaid) labor and hidden costs involved in building and maintaining functional archives, making it difficult to create sustainable and truly independent archives. Finally, increased access to the documentation of local histories can expose these resources to external interference, threatening the accuracy of records and undermining the autonomy of local political processes.

Thanks to the growing accessibility of tools for building and deploying interactive databases and applications, coupled with the abundance of available digital material, community-driven archiving has seen significant growth. Activists and historians are creating digital archives focused on specific causes or geographical regions. For instance, bak.ma (https://bak.ma/) serves as an impressive archive of videos documenting human rights struggles in Turkiye, built by Turkish historians and digital creators. Similarly, the Urban Video Archive (https://urbanvideoarchive.vercel.app/) documents the struggles of disenfranchised Brazilians, highlighting state brutality and their fight for rights. This archive is co-created by a video activist collective from Rio de Janeiro, an urban sociologist, and a media scholar and technologist. Yet, these initiatives rarely achieve the visibility enjoyed by large, well-funded institutions.

Scholars have long warned against the pitfalls of digital optimism, pointing to persistent hierarchies of wealth and power that reproduce themselves in new ways within the digital sphere (Hesmondhalgh 2019: 262–291). These hierarchies often sideline independent creators and projects in favor of institutionalized efforts. For example, organizations with significant resources often become dominant voices in the archiving field, shaping methodologies and practices that smaller projects must navigate carefully to gain visibility and legitimacy. When we were developing the Urban Video Archive, many experts we consulted suggested working with such organizations based in North America, given their established reputations and resources. While their support could have bolstered the archive's visibility, maintaining the independence of the project remained our priority.

The realities of funding and securing a safe server to host the videos forced us to seek institutional collaborations and grants. While some partnerships provided crucial support without compromising the archive's mission, others highlighted the challenges community-driven projects face in balancing resource needs with maintaining independence. Ensuring full authority over the archive's infrastructure and content required navigating complex negotiations, reflecting the broader tensions between grassroots efforts and the conditions often attached to institutional support (see Poole 2020). These tensions also expose a persistent issue for community archives: the hidden labor costs and financial burdens of building and maintaining archives often remain unaccounted for (Fischer et al. 2019; Kilberg 2024). Even as organizations with significant resources step in to fill gaps left by underfunded local initiatives, their involvement can create dependencies that further undermine grassroots autonomy.

Compounding these challenges is the way the accessibility of digital tools, while stimulating the growth of community archives, also leads to a saturated and "fragmented" market (Putnam 2024: 33). This saturation diminishes the visibility of individual archives and deepens systemic inequities. Larger institutions, bolstered by substantial funding and established reputations, dominate public attention, creating an uneven playing field where smaller, community-driven efforts struggle to gain recognition. As such, the sustainability of community archiving is jeopardized, not only by the disproportionate financial and labor costs that grassroots initiatives must bear but also by the

challenges of competing for visibility in an oversaturated digital landscape (see Kim 2022).

These dynamics also affect the accuracy and interpretation of archival content. When archives are shaped by the constraints of institutional dependence or are buried under the weight of digital oversaturation, the narratives they contain risk being misrepresented, co-opted, or ignored altogether. The practice of selecting records based on their "archivability" has been a significant aspect of how governmental and institutional archives contribute to the oppression of marginalized communities (Mbembe 2002: 19). The narratives of struggles against state and colonial powers have been the subject of loss and distortion, including whitewashing, for centuries, and institutional archives have played a major role in this regard—from South Africa to Canada. When Global North institutions dominate the preservation and interpretation of audiovisual documents from the Global South, they often sideline the nuanced complexities and diverse viewpoints within local contexts (Sorce / Dumitrica 2022: 159). Archives, including those documenting human rights abuses, are not neutral spaces. They can be political sites to serve geopolitical aims, with certain narratives emphasized or suppressed to advance specific interests (see e.g. Restuccia / Ballhaus 2024). Notably, non-governmental organizations (NGOs) that present themselves as neutral custodians of truth often rely on funding sources and affiliations tied to broader geopolitical power structures, which can shape their priorities and influence their activities (see Kamat 2004; Srinivas 2009).

This archival imperialism perpetuates a cycle of dependency. Activists and historians, lacking the resources to build and sustain their own archives, are often forced to rely on these institutions for preservation, visibility, and legitimacy. This reliance undermines their autonomy and leaves sensitive information vulnerable to exploitation or misuse.

The paradox becomes clear: increased accessibility to documentation tools does not necessarily lead to empowerment. Instead, it can render local communities susceptible to external forces that seek to control their narratives, often to the detriment of the very people whose stories are being told. This raises urgent questions about how to protect the independence and integrity of these archives while ensuring they serve the communities they document.

These issues of narrative sovereignty are not limited to historical and advocacy archives. They also arise in the dynamic, real-time documentation of political events on social media, which functions as an important form of archiving (see Neumayer / Struthers 2018). The 2022 protests in Iran offer a concrete case of how increased access to digital tools for documenting and disseminating local events can be exploited in ways that pose serious risks. Foreign-affiliated accounts, including some linked to Israeli interests, interfered by spreading misinformation and disinformation under the guise of supporting Iranian women. These accounts often circulated unverified, out-of-context, or debunked videos, amplifying tensions and exploiting the legitimate cause of the protestors in service of external agendas.

As such, the abundance of digital audiovisual documentation, meant to enhance local solidarity and document violations of human rights, facilitated broader imperialist policies of destabilizing nations in the Global South under the pretense of defending human rights. By circulating both real and fabricated videos and framing them with targeted narratives, these interventions amplified perceptions of violent clashes against the government, ultimately derailing the protests' original objectives. These actions also effectively bolstered the Iranian state's claims of foreign interference, prompting harsher crackdowns and treason charges against protesters.

At the same time, the engagement-driven algorithms of social media platforms incentivized accounts to post graphic and sensationalist content, often without regard for its impact beyond the digital sphere (Neumayer / Struthers 2018; Poell / van Dijck 2015). This dynamic exacerbated the disconnect between on-the-ground realities and how events were portrayed online. The 2022 protests thus underscored the complexities and dangers of increased accessibility to digital documentation, revealing how these tools can be weaponized to manipulate narratives and endanger those they are meant to empower.

While global access to digital documentation has played a crucial role in exposing human rights violations, it also raises significant concerns about sovereignty. Marshall McLuhan accurately stated that the "global village" formed by electronic media connects the world but also fosters an environment of intrusive curiosity. In his words, "everybody is maliciously engaged in poking his nose at everybody else's business" and demonstrates "much involvement in everybody else's life" (Fraumeni / Pintoff 1967). His observation underscores the complex dynamics of accessible interconnectedness in the mass media age.

The accessibility of digital devices and platforms not only empowers documentation but also increases the susceptibility of local populations to narratives and disinformation crafted by external actors. This dynamic, coupled with the rapid circulation of media content, challenges local communities' ability to independently interpret

their realities, making external influences a key factor in shaping both local and global perceptions. I will examine how media content attributed to Iran and disseminated on social media enabled external actors to shape narratives during the 2022 protests,focusing in particular on Twitter (X) and Telegram. On Twitter, I will collect tweets featuring hashtags such as #MahsaAmini, #WomanLifeFreedom, and #IranRevolution from several foreign-affiliated accounts in order to analyze their framing strategies and levels of public engagement (likes, retweets, replies). For Telegram, I will use the Telethon library to identify and scrape posts referencing the same hashtags and related narratives. My analysis will concentrate on public channels that were especially active during the protests. I will extract message content and metadata to detect recurring frames and dissemination patterns. Evaluating the factual grounding and narrative construction of these social media posts, I will explore how they may have influenced perceptions both locally and globally. As such, this study examines the role of increased access to digital documentation in amplifying disinformation and enabling external influence over public discourse.

This presentation aims to stimulate a critical conversation about the paradoxes of accessibility in digital archiving and information circulation. How does the rapid, often indiscriminate global flow of media content reshape local politics and power relations? Can community-driven archives mitigate these risks, and if so, what strategies and resources are needed to ensure their sustainability? Above all, how can we safeguard the autonomy and narrative sovereignty of local communities while preserving free, open access to vital information? These questions urge us to rethink digital infrastructure, funding mechanisms, and regulatory frameworks, challenging us to envision a more equitable and accountable digital future.

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